

IN PROFILE

The Polish School

Lutosławski was one of a group of Polish composers who in 1956, after the death of Stalin (who had imposed restrictions on artistic innovation), began an international festival of contemporary music, the Warsaw Autumn Festival, to showcase their work. Now free to experiment with new musical techniques, the group, which also included Henryk Górecki, Krzysztof Penderecki, and Kazimierz Sierocki, developed a distinctive new Polish approach to composition and, despite stylistic differences, became collectively known as “the Polish School.”

Born in Warsaw in 1913, Witold Lutosławski was the son of landowning aristocrats. After the outbreak of World War I, his father, Józef, active in Polish nationalist politics, took the family to Moscow to seek safety from German invasion, but the plan soon turned sour: the Bolshevik government made peace with Germany and in 1918 Józef and his brother were executed.

“ Polish culture suffered **terrible losses ...**
all **cultural activity** was **banned.** ”

WITOLD LUTOSLAWSKI, ON THE GERMAN
OCCUPATION OF POLAND (1939–1945), 1993